

Daily AI, Crypto & Tech Power Briefing

July 25, 2026

AI Infrastructure Becomes a National Industry, While Capital and Liquidity Set the Limits

South Korea is using industrial policy and partnerships with U.S. chip leaders to secure memory, accelerators and data-center capacity. At the same time, major AI companies are arguing that open models should remain available, shifting the policy debate from whether to regulate AI to how narrowly to target risk.

The financial test is getting sharper. Alphabet's first recorded cash burn shows how quickly AI buildout can strain even the strongest balance sheets, while Bitcoin's move below \$64,000 highlights weakening liquidity across crypto markets.

1. South Korea turns chips, memory and power into an AI industrial strategy

Reuters · July 25, 2026

Samsung Elec, SK Group seal \$950 bln deals as South Korea hosts AI powers

The story

Reuters reports that Samsung Electronics and SK Group announced \$950 billion of AI-related initiatives and partnerships as South Korea hosted technology leaders. The plans include SK Hynix and Nvidia working on high-bandwidth memory and large-scale data centers, plus a Samsung memorandum with Broadcom covering AI accelerators, memory, foundry work and advanced packaging.

A planned two-gigawatt AI data center is a useful marker of the ambition. The important point is not a single headline number, but the effort to link memory, chips, packaging, power and cloud capacity into one national supply chain.

Why it matters

AI infrastructure is becoming a strategic industry rather than a collection of separate hardware purchases. Countries and companies that secure scarce memory and power can influence who gets compute, at what cost and on what timetable.

For chip buyers, high-bandwidth memory and advanced packaging are now as consequential as the accelerator itself. A shortage in either layer can delay an entire data-center deployment.

What to watch

- Whether the announced partnerships become binding orders, capacity reservations or new factories.
- The delivery timetable for HBM4 memory, Vera Rubin systems and the two-gigawatt data center.
- How much of the investment is funded capital expenditure versus memoranda and long-term commercial commitments.

2. The AI industry asks Washington to regulate misuse without closing the open-model route

Reuters · July 24, 2026

[Nvidia, Microsoft and other tech giants back open-source AI models](#)

The story

Nvidia, Microsoft, Meta, IBM and other groups signed a public letter urging U.S. lawmakers not to impose broad early restrictions on open AI models, Reuters reports. The signatories argue that open models support competition, local deployment and security research, while opponents focus on the difficulty of controlling a model once its weights are widely available.

The letter arrives as policy attention has intensified after recent AI security concerns. It does not reject regulation; it makes the narrower argument that rules should focus on harmful acts and high-risk uses rather than treat every open release as the same problem.

Why it matters

The choice between open and closed models now affects procurement, sovereign-compute plans and cybersecurity as much as research culture. Open weights can lower switching costs, but they also transfer more responsibility for guardrails to the deployer.

For policymakers, the hardest task is to create enforceable obligations without giving incumbent platforms an unintended distribution advantage over smaller labs and enterprise users.

What to watch

- Whether lawmakers define high-risk capabilities by model size, functionality or real-world deployment.
- How liability, reporting and access-control requirements differ for open-weight and hosted models.
- Whether China-related security and intellectual-property concerns reshape the coalition's position.

3. Alphabet's cash burn puts the return on AI infrastructure at the center of the earnings debate

Reuters · July 23, 2026

Alphabet's cash burn raises alarm for Big Tech as AI spending climbs

The story

Reuters reports that Alphabet recorded its first cash burn on record as AI spending rose, even after strong cloud growth. The report says investors are preparing for further large outlays by Meta, Microsoft and Amazon, making cash generation and the financing of data centers a central market question rather than a technical footnote.

The situation is not simply a sign that demand is weak. It reflects the timing mismatch in infrastructure businesses: cash is committed upfront for chips, buildings and power, while utilization and recurring revenue arrive later.

Why it matters

AI capital expenditure is now a valuation issue. Investors want proof that higher spending produces durable cloud demand, inference revenue and margin expansion instead of only larger depreciation charges.

The financing structure matters too. Using debt, leases or off-balance-sheet vehicles can preserve short-term cash, but it changes who absorbs risk if AI demand or pricing disappoints.

What to watch

- Capital-expenditure guidance and free-cash-flow targets from the next round of hyperscaler earnings.
- Evidence on data-center utilization, cloud backlog and the cost of serving inference workloads.
- Whether lenders and credit-rating agencies begin to price AI infrastructure as a distinct financing risk.

4. Bitcoin's fall below \$64,000 puts stablecoin liquidity back in focus

Investing.com · July 25, 2026

Bitcoin price falls below \$64,000 as stablecoin inflows weaken

The story

Bitcoin traded below \$64,000 on Saturday after a further daily decline, with Investing.com pointing to weaker stablecoin inflows and lower transfers to exchanges. The move is a market signal rather than a verdict on long-term adoption, but it shows that available trading liquidity still matters more than narrative in the short run.

Stablecoins are the settlement layer for much of crypto trading. When fewer tokens move toward venues where traders can deploy them, the market may have less immediate buying power to absorb selling pressure.

Why it matters

Crypto investors often focus on exchange-traded fund flows or policy headlines, but on-chain liquidity and redemption behavior can shape price discovery first. A stablecoin is useful only if users trust its reserve assets and can move or redeem it reliably when markets are stressed.

For institutions, that makes stablecoin design a market-structure issue: custody, reserve quality, redemption mechanics and settlement access determine whether liquidity is real when it is needed.

What to watch

- Whether stablecoin issuance and exchange inflows stabilize after the latest decline.
 - Spot exchange-traded fund flows and derivatives positioning as a test of institutional demand.
 - The Commodity Futures Trading Commission's consultation on 24/7 and perpetual-style Bitcoin futures, which closes July 27.
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Professional terms

industrial policy - 产业政策	high-bandwidth memory (HBM) - 高带宽内存
advanced packaging - 先进封装	supply-chain bottleneck - 供应链瓶颈
compute capacity - 算力容量	capacity reservation - 产能预留
open-weight model - 开放权重模型	access control - 访问控制
model governance - 模型治理	capital expenditure - 资本支出
free cash flow - 自由现金流	depreciation charge - 折旧费用
inference cost - 推理成本	off-balance-sheet financing - 表外融资
valuation multiple - 估值倍数	stablecoin liquidity - 稳定币流动性
redemption mechanism - 赎回机制	reserve quality - 储备资产质量
custody risk - 托管风险	

Today's big picture

Today's big picture is that AI is becoming an infrastructure and financing business. Governments are organizing national supply chains, companies are debating how widely model capability should be distributed, and investors are asking when the cash committed to data centers turns into durable returns.

Crypto faces the same institutional reality in a different form. Price can change quickly, but lasting market depth depends on the plumbing underneath: credible reserves, reliable redemption, custody and channels that bring liquidity into the market when conditions become difficult.